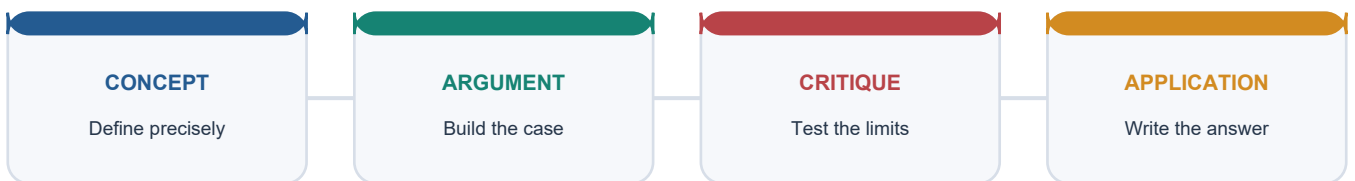


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Significance & Decline of Mauryan Rule - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Significance & Decline of Mauryan Rule - Solved Practice Workbook

Practice contract: exactly 32 original hard MCQs precede the verified PYQ block; strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation repeats eight times; 128 option explanations and 32 examiner traps are separately identifiable. Official PYQ option order and key status are preserved.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

These are original questions, not UPSC PYQs. Correct keys rotate A -> B -> C -> D exactly eight times. All 128 option explanations and all 32 examiner traps are separately identifiable.

Q1

Which formulation most accurately distinguishes the three historical objects in Topic 15?

- A. Ashoka's death, the later loss of imperial integration, and the afterlife of Mauryan practices are related but differently dated processes.
- B. Legacy means every Mauryan office survived unchanged under the Shungas.
- C. The dynasty ended first, followed by Ashoka's death and then imperial weakening.
- D. The empire, dynasty and legacy all ended in 232 BCE.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Ashoka died in 232 BCE, while the dynasty conventionally ended c. 187/185 BCE; imperial integration weakened unevenly and selected practices and symbols outlived both. The distinction prevents political decline from becoming a claim of civilisational disappearance. Named evidence: Upinder Singh pp. 961-965; repository Master Chronology. Qualification: Do not use 232 BCE as a universal end-date. [Q01-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "Legacy means every Mauryan office survived unchanged under the Shungas." fails this empire, dynasty and legacy test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh pp. 961-965; repository Master Chronology. [Q01-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "The dynasty ended first, followed by Ashoka's death and then imperial weakening." fails this empire, dynasty and legacy test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh pp. 961-965; repository Master Chronology. [Q01-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "The empire, dynasty and legacy all ended in 232 BCE." fails this empire, dynasty and legacy test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh pp. 961-965; repository Master Chronology. [Q01-D]

Examiner trap 1: Do not use 232 BCE as a universal end-date.

Q2

Why is the expression 'first virtually subcontinental empire' preferable to 'first uniformly all-India state'?

- A. It denies that the north-west formed part of Mauryan political geography.
- B. It recognises unprecedented scale while preserving the regional limits and graded character of control.
- C. It treats every southern polity named in an edict as a directly governed province.
- D. It means the Mauryas ruled only the middle Ganga valley.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "It denies that the north-west formed part of Mauryan political geography." fails this virtually subcontinental empire test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961 and Chapter 7 conclusion; Ashokan edict geography. [Q02-A]
- **B:** Correct. Upinder's formulation captures both scale and qualification. Southern neighbours and peripheries should not be annexed merely because they appear in the edictal horizon, and control varied by core, corridor and frontier. Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961 and Chapter 7 conclusion; Ashokan edict geography. Qualification: Scale and uniformity are not synonyms. [Q02-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "It treats every southern polity named in an edict as a directly governed province." fails this virtually subcontinental empire test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961 and Chapter 7 conclusion; Ashokan edict geography. [Q02-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "It means the Mauryas ruled only the middle Ganga valley." fails this virtually subcontinental empire test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961 and Chapter 7 conclusion; Ashokan edict geography. [Q02-D]

Examiner trap 2: Scale and uniformity are not synonyms.

Q3

Which later Maurya provides the clearest contemporary inscriptional bridge after Ashoka?

- A. Samprati through a complete series of empire-wide pillar edicts.
- B. Shalishuka through named silver portrait coins.
- C. Dasharatha through the Nagarjuni cave inscriptions.
- D. Brihadratha through a contemporary account of Pushyamitra's coup.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "Samprati through a complete series of empire-wide pillar edicts." fails this later-maurya epigraphy test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961; Nagarjuni cave inscriptions. [Q03-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "Shalishuka through named silver portrait coins." fails this later-maurya epigraphy test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961; Nagarjuni cave inscriptions. [Q03-B]
- **C:** Correct. Upinder Singh states that Dasharatha is the only later Maurya known to have issued inscriptions. The Nagarjuni cave dedications also demonstrate selective continuation of Ajivika patronage after Ashoka. Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961; Nagarjuni cave inscriptions. Qualification: Later dynastic lists are not equivalent to contemporary inscriptions. [Q03-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "Brihadratha through a contemporary account of Pushyamitra's coup." fails this later-maurya epigraphy test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961; Nagarjuni cave inscriptions. [Q03-D]

Examiner trap 3: Later dynastic lists are not equivalent to contemporary inscriptions.

Q4

For reconstructing the precise post-Ashoka succession, which evidence problem is most serious?

- A. Ashokan edicts provide a complete list of later rulers and their reign lengths.
- B. Coins carry unambiguous portraits and names of every later Maurya.
- C. Archaeological layers identify each successor and the exact year each province separated.

- D. Puranic, Buddhist and Jain lists are later and divergent, while contemporary inscriptions become very sparse.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "Ashokan edicts provide a complete list of later rulers and their reign lengths." fails this source hierarchy test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961; repository source-method conventions. [Q04-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "Coins carry unambiguous portraits and names of every later Maurya." fails this source hierarchy test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961; repository source-method conventions. [Q04-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "Archaeological layers identify each successor and the exact year each province separated." fails this source hierarchy test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961; repository source-method conventions. [Q04-C]
- **D:** Correct. The post-Ashoka archive is thin. Traditions preserve names and memories but differ, archaeology supplies material sequences without automatically naming rulers, and Mauryan punch-marked coins are hard to assign to individuals. Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961; repository source-method conventions. Qualification: Chronological uncertainty must be stated, not filled with invented precision. [Q04-D]

Examiner trap 4: Chronological uncertainty must be stated, not filled with invented precision.

Q5

Which combination best represents Ashoka's regionally adapted public communication?

- A. Prakrit-Brahmi across much of the empire, Kharoshthi in the north-west, and Greek/Aramaic versions in selected north-western contexts.
- B. Sanskrit-Devanagari throughout the empire with no regional variation.
- C. Tamil-Brahmi only in the Ganga valley and Greek only at Sarnath.
- D. Pali-Kharoshthi in Kalinga and Latin-Aramaic at Pataliputra.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. The script-language pattern is a key legacy of inscriptional governance and regional adaptation. It should not be converted into a simple ethnic map or proof of equal administrative penetration. Named evidence: Ashokan inscriptional corpus; Topic 14 bounded evidence. Qualification: Most edicts were not in Sanskrit. [Q05-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "Sanskrit-Devanagari throughout the empire with no regional variation." fails this multilingual communication test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Ashokan inscriptional corpus; Topic 14 bounded evidence. [Q05-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "Tamil-Brahmi only in the Ganga valley and Greek only at Sarnath." fails this multilingual communication test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Ashokan inscriptional corpus; Topic 14 bounded evidence. [Q05-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "Pali-Kharoshthi in Kalinga and Latin-Aramaic at Pataliputra." fails this multilingual communication test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Ashokan inscriptional corpus; Topic 14 bounded evidence. [Q05-D]

Examiner trap 5: Most edicts were not in Sanskrit.

Q6

What is the strongest historical inference from the Sarnath lion capital's modern national-emblem status?

- A. Every element of the modern emblem reproduces the ancient capital without adaptation.
- B. A Mauryan monument acquired a new republican meaning, illustrating selective reinterpretation rather than institutional continuity.
- C. The capital proves Ashoka governed through modern constitutional nationalism.

- D. The Mauryan monarchy legally continued into the Indian republic.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "Every element of the modern emblem reproduces the ancient capital without adaptation." fails this national-symbol afterlife test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: ASI Sarnath Circle; Upinder Singh p. 964. [Q06-A]
- **B:** Correct. ASI identifies the lion capital as Mauryan/Ashokan and a national crest, while Upinder highlights its modern political memory. The afterlife is symbolic and historiographical, not a survival of Mauryan sovereignty. Named evidence: ASI Sarnath Circle; Upinder Singh p. 964. Qualification: Modern appropriation is not ancient institutional continuity. [Q06-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "The capital proves Ashoka governed through modern constitutional nationalism." fails this national-symbol afterlife test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: ASI Sarnath Circle; Upinder Singh p. 964. [Q06-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "The Mauryan monarchy legally continued into the Indian republic." fails this national-symbol afterlife test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: ASI Sarnath Circle; Upinder Singh p. 964. [Q06-D]

Examiner trap 6: Modern appropriation is not ancient institutional continuity.

Q7

Which statement about Sanchi most accurately demonstrates continuity through transformation?

- A. All stone railings and gateways were completed by Ashoka.
- B. Sanchi proves a total Buddhist rupture under the Shungas.
- C. An Ashokan brick stupa and pillar were enlarged and embellished under later dynasties, so the visible complex is multi-period.
- D. The site was abandoned immediately after 232 BCE and never received later patronage.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "All stone railings and gateways were completed by Ashoka." fails this sanchi layering test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: UNESCO Buddhist Monuments at Sanchi. [Q07-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "Sanchi proves a total Buddhist rupture under the Shungas." fails this sanchi layering test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: UNESCO Buddhist Monuments at Sanchi. [Q07-B]
- **C:** Correct. UNESCO distinguishes the Mauryan brick core and pillar from later Shunga enlargement and Satavahana gateway ornamentation. The site therefore refutes both 'all Ashokan' and 'total post-Mauryan rupture' narratives. Named evidence: UNESCO Buddhist Monuments at Sanchi. Qualification: Always date monument layers separately. [Q07-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "The site was abandoned immediately after 232 BCE and never received later patronage." fails this sanchi layering test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: UNESCO Buddhist Monuments at Sanchi. [Q07-D]

Examiner trap 7: Always date monument layers separately.

Q8

Why are Dasharatha's Nagarjuni cave inscriptions especially valuable for Topic 15?

- A. They document the Bactrian Greek invasion year by year.
- B. They prove all Ashokan officials and provinces continued unchanged.
- C. They establish a Brahmanical revolution immediately after Ashoka.

- D. They provide contemporary evidence for later-Maurya royal patronage of Ajivikas after Ashoka.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "They document the Bactrian Greek invasion year by year." fails this cave patronage continuity test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Nagarjuni cave inscriptions; Upinder Singh p. 961. [Q08-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "They prove all Ashokan officials and provinces continued unchanged." fails this cave patronage continuity test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: Nagarjuni cave inscriptions; Upinder Singh p. 961. [Q08-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "They establish a Brahmanical revolution immediately after Ashoka." fails this cave patronage continuity test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Nagarjuni cave inscriptions; Upinder Singh p. 961. [Q08-C]
- **D:** Correct. The inscriptions offer a rare post-Ashoka royal voice and complicate claims of instant religious reversal. Their reach is limited: cave donation does not map the later empire. Named evidence: Nagarjuni cave inscriptions; Upinder Singh p. 961. Qualification: A patronage inscription is not a territorial survey. [Q08-D]

Examiner trap 8: A patronage inscription is not a territorial survey.

Q9

Which is the strongest evidence supporting the weak-successor interpretation?

- A. The first three long reigns were followed by many short reigns, with a sharp reduction in contemporary royal inscriptions.
- B. A contemporary census ranks every later Maurya as incompetent.
- C. Every province issued a dated declaration against each successor.
- D. Ashoka ordered that no competent heir could succeed him.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. The reign pattern and epigraphic thinning support instability, but the adjective 'weak' often rests on later lists. A good answer treats succession as a trigger that interacted with structural and regional pressures. Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961. Qualification: Short reigns suggest instability; they do not explain every mechanism. [Q09-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "A contemporary census ranks every later Maurya as incompetent." fails this weak-successor theory test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961. [Q09-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "Every province issued a dated declaration against each successor." fails this weak-successor theory test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961. [Q09-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "Ashoka ordered that no competent heir could succeed him." fails this weak-successor theory test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961. [Q09-D]

Examiner trap 9: Short reigns suggest instability; they do not explain every mechanism.

Q10

What is the best criticism of explaining Mauryan decline only through weak successors?

- A. There is complete evidence that provincial institutions were wholly autonomous.
- B. It does not explain why particular regions detached, how frontier pressure operated, or why material-economic processes continued.
- C. The later Mauryas all had longer reigns than Chandragupta.

- D. Ancient empires never depended on rulers.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "There is complete evidence that provincial institutions were wholly autonomous." fails this limits of personality theory test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Multi-causal synthesis from Upinder Singh and repository answer architecture. [Q10-A]
- **B:** Correct. Ruler quality matters only through institutions, loyalties, armies and regions. The theory becomes persuasive when succession shocks are linked to integration costs and regional opportunities. Named evidence: Multi-causal synthesis from Upinder Singh and repository answer architecture. Qualification: Biography must be converted into a mechanism. [Q10-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "The later Mauryas all had longer reigns than Chandragupta." fails this limits of personality theory test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Multi-causal synthesis from Upinder Singh and repository answer architecture. [Q10-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "Ancient empires never depended on rulers." fails this limits of personality theory test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: Multi-causal synthesis from Upinder Singh and repository answer architecture. [Q10-D]

Examiner trap 10: Biography must be converted into a mechanism.

Q11

Under a strongly centralised model, why would rapid succession be especially destabilising?

- A. A centralised state requires no revenue or communication.
- B. All local elites become politically irrelevant forever.
- C. Appointments, reporting, military command and provincial loyalty would depend heavily on continuity at the centre.
- D. Centralisation automatically abolishes distance.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "A centralised state requires no revenue or communication." fails this centralisation mechanism test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Rock Edicts III and VI; centralisation debate in Topic 14. [Q11-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "All local elites become politically irrelevant forever." fails this centralisation mechanism test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Rock Edicts III and VI; centralisation debate in Topic 14. [Q11-B]
- **C:** Correct. A top-heavy system magnifies the effects of court instability. However, this model must be qualified by evidence of local mediation and differentiated control. Named evidence: Rock Edicts III and VI; centralisation debate in Topic 14. Qualification: Explain the transmission mechanism, not merely 'overcentralisation'. [Q11-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "Centralisation automatically abolishes distance." fails this centralisation mechanism test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Rock Edicts III and VI; centralisation debate in Topic 14. [Q11-D]

Examiner trap 11: Explain the transmission mechanism, not merely 'overcentralisation'.

Q12

If Mauryan rule was regionally differentiated rather than uniform, what follows for decline analysis?

- A. The empire must be reclassified as a purely imaginary state.
- B. No province could ever separate because it already had autonomy.
- C. Weak rulers become completely irrelevant to every region.

- D. Local mediation could reduce daily central burdens yet make political detachment easier when central prestige and coercion weakened.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "The empire must be reclassified as a purely imaginary state." fails this differentiated-control implication test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Fussman/Thapar differentiated-control debate; Upinder Singh p. 963. [Q12-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "No province could ever separate because it already had autonomy." fails this differentiated-control implication test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: Fussman/Thapar differentiated-control debate; Upinder Singh p. 963. [Q12-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "Weak rulers become completely irrelevant to every region." fails this differentiated-control implication test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Fussman/Thapar differentiated-control debate; Upinder Singh p. 963. [Q12-C]
- **D:** Correct. Differentiation is double-edged: it can stabilise a large empire through intermediaries and create autonomous capacities that later support regionalisation. It does not erase strategic central power. Named evidence: Fussman/Thapar differentiated-control debate; Upinder Singh p. 963. Qualification: Avoid both unitary-state and symbolic-empire extremes. [Q12-D]

Examiner trap 12: Avoid both unitary-state and symbolic-empire extremes.

Q13

Which verdict best reflects Upinder Singh's assessment of a Mauryan fiscal crisis?

- A. Large imperial costs make strain plausible, but there is no direct evidence for either a state fiscal crisis or a wider economic crisis.
- B. Coin hoards demonstrate that all taxes ceased after Ashoka.
- C. Treasury accounts prove bankruptcy immediately after Kalinga.
- D. The Arthashastra records the exact terminal Mauryan deficit.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Upinder explicitly rejects claims of proven fiscal/economic crisis. Structural expenditure on army and officialdom can be discussed, but not converted into a documented bankruptcy. Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 962. Qualification: Plausible cost is not proven crisis. [Q13-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "Coin hoards demonstrate that all taxes ceased after Ashoka." fails this fiscal-crisis evidence test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 962. [Q13-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "Treasury accounts prove bankruptcy immediately after Kalinga." fails this fiscal-crisis evidence test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 962. [Q13-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "The Arthashastra records the exact terminal Mauryan deficit." fails this fiscal-crisis evidence test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 962. [Q13-D]

Examiner trap 13: Plausible cost is not proven crisis.

Q14

Which proposition is evidence-secure?

- A. Rock Edict XIII records a constitutional ban on defensive force.
- B. Ashoka renounced aggressive conquest but did not disband the army.

- C. Ashoka abolished all military institutions after Kalinga.
- D. Ashoka transferred the entire army to Buddhist monasteries.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "Rock Edict XIII records a constitutional ban on defensive force." fails this army disbandment trap test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 962; Rock Edict XIII. [Q14-A]
- **B:** Correct. Upinder stresses Ashoka's pragmatism: army, punishment and warnings remained. The pacifism thesis must therefore be framed as a possible preparedness issue, not demilitarisation. Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 962; Rock Edict XIII. Qualification: Renunciation of aggression is not abolition of defence. [Q14-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "Ashoka abolished all military institutions after Kalinga." fails this army disbandment trap test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 962; Rock Edict XIII. [Q14-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "Ashoka transferred the entire army to Buddhist monasteries." fails this army disbandment trap test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 962; Rock Edict XIII. [Q14-D]

Examiner trap 14: Renunciation of aggression is not abolition of defence.

Q15

Which evidence most directly counters the claim that dhamma eliminated coercive kingship?

- A. The Sarnath capital contains four lions.
- B. The Rummindei inscription reduces a fiscal levy.
- C. Pillar Edict IV presupposes capital punishment while regulating justice and reprieve.
- D. The Bhabru edict recommends Buddhist texts.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "The Sarnath capital contains four lions." fails this capital punishment test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Pillar Edict IV. [Q15-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "The Rummindei inscription reduces a fiscal levy." fails this capital punishment test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Pillar Edict IV. [Q15-B]
- **C:** Correct. Pillar Edict IV shows reform and restraint within a punitive order. It is therefore relevant to decline debates that mistakenly equate dhamma with a powerless state. Named evidence: Pillar Edict IV. Qualification: Ethical reform can coexist with coercion. [Q15-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "The Bhabru edict recommends Buddhist texts." fails this capital punishment test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Pillar Edict IV. [Q15-D]

Examiner trap 15: Ethical reform can coexist with coercion.

Q16

What does Ashoka's warning to forest peoples in Rock Edict XIII demonstrate?

- A. Every forest community immediately joined the Mauryan army.
- B. Ashoka withdrew from Kalinga and dissolved frontier administration.
- C. The empire renounced punishment in all circumstances.
- D. Remorse and dhamma-vijaya coexisted with retained deterrent power.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "Every forest community immediately joined the Mauryan army." fails this forest warning test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Major Rock Edict XIII. [Q16-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "Ashoka withdrew from Kalinga and dissolved frontier administration." fails this forest warning test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: Major Rock Edict XIII. [Q16-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "The empire renounced punishment in all circumstances." fails this forest warning test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Major Rock Edict XIII. [Q16-C]
- **D:** Correct. The warning is decisive counter-evidence to total-pacifism claims. It does not quantify military readiness, but it proves coercion remained part of royal self-presentation. Named evidence: Major Rock Edict XIII. Qualification: Use the warning as counter-evidence, not troop statistics. [Q16-D]

Examiner trap 16: Use the warning as counter-evidence, not troop statistics.

Q17

Which inscriptional pattern most strongly weakens an empirewide anti-Brahmana-policy thesis?

- A. Ashoka repeatedly exhorted respect for both Brahmanas and shramanas.
- B. Ashoka ordered the destruction of all Vedic texts.
- C. Dasharatha prohibited Ajivika patronage.
- D. Every edict was written exclusively for Buddhist monks.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. The edicts do not support blanket persecution of Brahmanas. Specific ritual grievances may be hypothesised, but the broad revolution thesis lacks inscriptional foundation. Named evidence: Major Rock Edicts and Upinder Singh p. 962. Qualification: Do not infer persecution from heterodox patronage. [Q17-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "Ashoka ordered the destruction of all Vedic texts." fails this brahmanical-reaction counter-evidence test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Major Rock Edicts and Upinder Singh p. 962. [Q17-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "Dasharatha prohibited Ajivika patronage." fails this brahmanical-reaction counter-evidence test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Major Rock Edicts and Upinder Singh p. 962. [Q17-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "Every edict was written exclusively for Buddhist monks." fails this brahmanical-reaction counter-evidence test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Major Rock Edicts and Upinder Singh p. 962. [Q17-D]

Examiner trap 17: Do not infer persecution from heterodox patronage.

Q18

What is the most defensible use of Ashoka's restrictions on sacrifice in decline analysis?

- A. They ended animal killing throughout the empire with complete compliance.
- B. They may have displeased some ritual specialists, but the scale and political consequence of such grievance are unproven.
- C. They prove every Brahmana joined Pushyamitra in a coordinated revolt.
- D. They demonstrate that Brahmanas disappeared from Mauryan society.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "They ended animal killing throughout the empire with complete compliance." fails this sacrifice restriction test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Rock Edict I and Upinder Singh p. 962. [Q18-A]
- **B:** Correct. Upinder allows the possibility of grievance among Brahmanas dependent on sacrifice, but balances it with explicit respect for Brahmanas and plural patronage. The mechanism remains bounded. Named evidence: Rock Edict I and Upinder Singh p. 962. Qualification: Possible grievance is not proven revolution. [Q18-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "They prove every Brahmana joined Pushyamitra in a coordinated revolt." fails this sacrifice restriction test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Rock Edict I and Upinder Singh p. 962. [Q18-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "They demonstrate that Brahmanas disappeared from Mauryan society." fails this sacrifice restriction test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: Rock Edict I and Upinder Singh p. 962. [Q18-D]

Examiner trap 18: Possible grievance is not proven revolution.

Q19

What can the Pushyamitra-Brihadratha transition establish most securely?

- A. Every Mauryan province simultaneously revolted for religious reasons.
- B. Ashoka had selected Pushyamitra as his successor.
- C. A military commander replaced the last Maurya in the conventional dynastic narrative; it does not by itself explain earlier empirewide disintegration.
- D. The economy collapsed on the day of the coup.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "Every Mauryan province simultaneously revolted for religious reasons." fails this pushyamitra coup test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Later dynastic tradition; Master Chronology. [Q19-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "Ashoka had selected Pushyamitra as his successor." fails this pushyamitra coup test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Later dynastic tradition; Master Chronology. [Q19-B]
- **C:** Correct. The coup marks dynastic termination at the centre after a longer weakening process. Pushyamitra's Brahmana identity and Vedic rites concern successor legitimization, not automatic proof of the cause of imperial decline. Named evidence: Later dynastic tradition; Master Chronology. Qualification: Final event and long causal process must be separated. [Q19-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "The economy collapsed on the day of the coup." fails this pushyamitra coup test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Later dynastic tradition; Master Chronology. [Q19-D]

Examiner trap 19: Final event and long causal process must be separated.

Q20

How should Buddhist narratives of Pushyamitra's persecution be handled?

- A. As modern archaeological reports.
- B. As Ashokan edicts issued by Pushyamitra.
- C. As official UPSC answer keys.
- D. As later sectarian memories requiring corroboration, not as self-verifying contemporary chronicles.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "As modern archaeological reports." fails this persecution traditions test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Later Buddhist traditions; Sanchi archaeological continuity. [Q20-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "As Ashokan edicts issued by Pushyamitra." fails this persecution traditions test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: Later Buddhist traditions; Sanchi archaeological continuity. [Q20-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "As official UPSC answer keys." fails this persecution traditions test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Later Buddhist traditions; Sanchi archaeological continuity. [Q20-C]
- **D:** Correct. The narratives matter for memory and religious conflict, but date, genre and purpose limit their direct causal use. Archaeology such as continued Sanchi activity complicates a total-rupture reading. Named evidence: Later Buddhist traditions; Sanchi archaeological continuity. Qualification: Source criticism is not dismissal; it defines evidentiary reach. [Q20-D]

Examiner trap 20: Source criticism is not dismissal; it defines evidentiary reach.

Q21

The famous Taxila complaints against wicked officials are best classified as:

- A. Later Buddhist narrative evidence preserving a memory of centre-province conflict.
- B. A contemporary Ashokan pillar edict from Taxila.
- C. An Indo-Greek bilingual coin legend.
- D. A Puranic fiscal schedule.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Divyavadana/Ashokavadana traditions are useful for remembered administrative oppression but are not contemporary administrative files. They should be paired with direct Kalinga edictal concern. Named evidence: Divyavadana/Ashokavadana tradition; Sharma p. 208. Qualification: Always name the later narrative genre. [Q21-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "A contemporary Ashokan pillar edict from Taxila." fails this taxila complaint source test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Divyavadana/Ashokavadana tradition; Sharma p. 208. [Q21-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "An Indo-Greek bilingual coin legend." fails this taxila complaint source test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Divyavadana/Ashokavadana tradition; Sharma p. 208. [Q21-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "A Puranic fiscal schedule." fails this taxila complaint source test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Divyavadana/Ashokavadana tradition; Sharma p. 208. [Q21-D]

Examiner trap 21: Always name the later narrative genre.

Q22

What do the Separate Kalinga Edicts establish most directly?

- A. All officials across the empire were removed.
- B. Ashoka was concerned about arbitrary imprisonment, official behaviour, confidence and just administration in a conquered province.
- C. The death penalty was abolished throughout India.
- D. Kalinga successfully expelled the Mauryas immediately after the war.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "All officials across the empire were removed." fails this kalinga justice edicts test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Separate Kalinga Edicts I-II. [Q22-A]
- **B:** Correct. The edicts reveal corrective governance and the principal-agent problem. They do not document a later Kalinga revolt or prove that reforms succeeded. Named evidence: Separate Kalinga Edicts I-II. Qualification: Royal concern is not the same as verified compliance. [Q22-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "The death penalty was abolished throughout India." fails this kalinga justice edicts test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Separate Kalinga Edicts I-II. [Q22-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "Kalinga successfully expelled the Mauryas immediately after the war." fails this kalinga justice edicts test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: Separate Kalinga Edicts I-II. [Q22-D]

Examiner trap 22: Royal concern is not the same as verified compliance.

Q23

Which statement best captures provincial assertion in a multi-causal model?

- A. All regions waited passively for Pushyamitra's coup.
- B. Provincial agency rules out any role for frontier invasion.
- C. Regional elites could redirect revenue, troops and legitimacy when succession and central coordination weakened.
- D. Regional states had no connection with earlier routes or material culture.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "All regions waited passively for Pushyamitra's coup." fails this regional agency test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Regional successor evidence; Sharma pp. 208-211. [Q23-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "Provincial agency rules out any role for frontier invasion." fails this regional agency test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Regional successor evidence; Sharma pp. 208-211. [Q23-B]
- **C:** Correct. Regional actors converted structural opportunity into new polities. This mechanism interacts with weak succession, communication costs and frontier pressure rather than replacing them. Named evidence: Regional successor evidence; Sharma pp. 208-211. Qualification: Regions are agents, not empty spaces on an imperial map. [Q23-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "Regional states had no connection with earlier routes or material culture." fails this regional agency test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Regional successor evidence; Sharma pp. 208-211. [Q23-D]

Examiner trap 23: Regions are agents, not empty spaces on an imperial map.

Q24

What does Dasharatha's dedication of Nagarjuni caves to Ajivikas most strongly imply?

- A. Brahmanical reaction was complete in 232 BCE.
- B. Buddhism was legally banned after Ashoka.
- C. Dasharatha restored the empire to Ashoka's full extent.
- D. Some Mauryan traditions of plural royal patronage continued after Ashoka.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "Brahmanical reaction was complete in 232 BCE." fails this dasharatha and religious plurality test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Nagarjuni cave inscriptions. [Q24-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "Buddhism was legally banned after Ashoka." fails this dasharatha and religious plurality test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: Nagarjuni cave inscriptions. [Q24-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "Dasharatha restored the empire to Ashoka's full extent." fails this dasharatha and religious plurality test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Nagarjuni cave inscriptions. [Q24-C]
- **D:** Correct. The dedication is narrow but important contemporary evidence. It counters claims of an immediate, total orthodox reversal while revealing nothing certain about the full territorial state. Named evidence: Nagarjuni cave inscriptions. Qualification: Use precise continuity, not sweeping continuity. [Q24-D]

Examiner trap 24: Use precise continuity, not sweeping continuity.

Q25

Which external factor does Upinder Singh explicitly identify as further weakening the Mauryan Empire?

- A. An invasion by the Bactrian Greeks.
- B. A Roman naval blockade of Pataliputra.
- C. A Gupta conquest of Taxila.
- D. A Kushana invasion during Ashoka's reign.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Bactrian Greek pressure is one of the firmer externally framed contributors in the consulted synthesis. Its strongest direct explanatory reach is the north-west. Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961. Qualification: Frontier pressure must be regionally bounded. [Q25-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "A Roman naval blockade of Pataliputra." fails this bactrian greek pressure test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961. [Q25-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "A Gupta conquest of Taxila." fails this bactrian greek pressure test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961. [Q25-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "A Kushana invasion during Ashoka's reign." fails this bactrian greek pressure test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961. [Q25-D]

Examiner trap 25: Frontier pressure must be regionally bounded.

Q26

How should Sharma's c. 206 BCE Greek-invasion date be used?

- A. As the date Ashoka disbanded his army.
- B. As a conventional textbook chronology placed before the dynastic end, with source and regional qualification.
- C. As an exact date proving all provinces fell on the same day.
- D. As evidence that Alexander personally destroyed the Mauryas.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "As the date Ashoka disbanded his army." fails this frontier chronology test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: R. S. Sharma pp. 209-210; Upinder Singh p. 961. [Q26-A]
- **B:** Correct. The date helps sequence north-western pressure, but it should not be treated as a complete all-India decline chronology. Upinder's wording remains more general. Named evidence: R. S. Sharma pp. 209-210; Upinder Singh p. 961. Qualification: Use exact dates only at the confidence level of the source. [Q26-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "As an exact date proving all provinces fell on the same day." fails this frontier chronology test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: R. S. Sharma pp. 209-210; Upinder Singh p. 961. [Q26-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "As evidence that Alexander personally destroyed the Mauryas." fails this frontier chronology test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: R. S. Sharma pp. 209-210; Upinder Singh p. 961. [Q26-D]

Examiner trap 26: Use exact dates only at the confidence level of the source.

Q27

Why was the north-west a distinct decline zone?

- A. It had no cities or trade routes.
- B. It was the only region where Ashoka issued Brahmi inscriptions.
- C. It faced trans-Hindu Kush political pressure, frontier-route competition and a history of multilingual local mediation.
- D. It lay outside all Hellenistic connections.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "It had no cities or trade routes." fails this north-western exposure test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Kandahar/Shahbazgarhi/Mansehra evidence; Topic 16 bounded context. [Q27-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "It was the only region where Ashoka issued Brahmi inscriptions." fails this north-western exposure test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Kandahar/Shahbazgarhi/Mansehra evidence; Topic 16 bounded context. [Q27-B]
- **C:** Correct. Taxila-Gandhara linked the subcontinent to Bactria and western/central Asia. Its frontier dynamics cannot be generalised mechanically to Kalinga or the Deccan. Named evidence: Kandahar/Shahbazgarhi/Mansehra evidence; Topic 16 bounded context. Qualification: One regional cause does not become an all-India cause. [Q27-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "It lay outside all Hellenistic connections." fails this north-western exposure test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Kandahar/Shahbazgarhi/Mansehra evidence; Topic 16 bounded context. [Q27-D]

Examiner trap 27: One regional cause does not become an all-India cause.

Q28

Which paired transition is most accurate?

- A. Kalinga: Gupta rule in 232 BCE; centre: Chola conquest.
- B. Deccan: immediate Kushana rule; north-west: Satavahana rule.
- C. Far south: direct Shunga province; north-west: no successor polity.
- D. North-west: Bactrian/Indo-Greek pressure; Ganga-centre: later Mauryas followed by Shunga transition.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "Kalinga: Gupta rule in 232 BCE; centre: Chola conquest." fails this regional differentiation test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Master Chronology; Topics 16-17 bounded context. [Q28-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "Deccan: immediate Kushana rule; north-west: Satavahana rule." fails this regional differentiation test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: Master Chronology; Topics 16-17 bounded context. [Q28-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "Far south: direct Shunga province; north-west: no successor polity." fails this regional differentiation test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Master Chronology; Topics 16-17 bounded context. [Q28-C]
- **D:** Correct. Post-Mauryan outcomes were asynchronous and regional. The pair preserves the principal geographical contrast without claiming exact dates for every local separation. Named evidence: Master Chronology; Topics 16-17 bounded context. Qualification: Build a regional map, not a single queue. [Q28-D]

Examiner trap 28: Build a regional map, not a single queue.

Q29

Which statement best represents Upinder Singh's economic conclusion?

- A. Agrarian expansion, urbanisation, trade and the money economy continued; political decline should not be equated with economy-wide collapse.
- B. Coin use ceased throughout India in 232 BCE.
- C. The post-Mauryan period had no long-distance commerce.
- D. All cities were abandoned immediately after Ashoka.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. The broad processes crossed dynastic boundaries and expanded in many post-Mauryan regions. Local contraction remains possible but requires site-specific evidence. Named evidence: Upinder Singh pp. 963-965. Qualification: Dynastic chronology is not automatically economic chronology. [Q29-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "Coin use ceased throughout India in 232 BCE." fails this economic-continuity verdict test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh pp. 963-965. [Q29-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "The post-Mauryan period had no long-distance commerce." fails this economic-continuity verdict test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh pp. 963-965. [Q29-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "All cities were abandoned immediately after Ashoka." fails this economic-continuity verdict test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh pp. 963-965. [Q29-D]

Examiner trap 29: Dynastic chronology is not automatically economic chronology.

Q30

What can a post-Mauryan coin hoard most safely establish?

- A. Universal replacement of barter by coin.
- B. Circulation, accumulation and political/economic activity in a specific context, not an all-India prosperity rate.
- C. The exact GDP of the issuing dynasty.
- D. The date every Mauryan official lost office.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "Universal replacement of barter by coin." fails this coins as evidence test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Numismatic method; Topics 14 and 16. [Q30-A]
- **B:** Correct. Coins are powerful for authority, iconography, chronology and exchange, but require archaeological context. Mauryan punch-marked coins are especially difficult to assign to individual rulers. Named evidence: Numismatic method; Topics 14 and 16. Qualification: Coins are not fiscal accounts or GDP. [Q30-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "The exact GDP of the issuing dynasty." fails this coins as evidence test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Numismatic method; Topics 14 and 16. [Q30-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "The date every Mauryan official lost office." fails this coins as evidence test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: Numismatic method; Topics 14 and 16. [Q30-D]

Examiner trap 30: Coins are not fiscal accounts or GDP.

Q31

Which archaeological pattern most strongly challenges a sudden 'economic collapse' narrative?

- A. A single later literary claim about an empty treasury.
- B. The disappearance of every settlement after 232 BCE.
- C. Urban layers, craft activity, brick/ring-well use and coin circulation continue across Mauryan and post-Mauryan phases at multiple centres.
- D. The absence of a modern census.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "A single later literary claim about an empty treasury." fails this urban archaeology test. It asserts direct continuity, uniformity or precision where the surviving archive supports only a qualified inference. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh conclusion; early-historic archaeology. [Q31-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "The disappearance of every settlement after 232 BCE." fails this urban archaeology test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh conclusion; early-historic archaeology. [Q31-B]
- **C:** Correct. Material continuities and later urban growth show restructuring rather than universal collapse. Each site's stratigraphy must still be dated separately. Named evidence: Upinder Singh conclusion; early-historic archaeology. Qualification: Use site, phase and indicator. [Q31-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. "The absence of a modern census." fails this urban archaeology test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: Upinder Singh conclusion; early-historic archaeology. [Q31-D]

Examiner trap 31: Use site, phase and indicator.

Q32

How does Sharma connect Mauryan significance with later regionalisation?

- A. Regional states arose without agrarian or material bases.
- B. Mauryas prevented iron and brick technology from leaving Pataliputra.
- C. Every successor copied the Mauryan constitution word for word.
- D. The spread of material culture and state knowledge reduced Magadha's special advantage and enabled new regional states.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. "Regional states arose without agrarian or material bases." fails this material diffusion hypothesis test. It collapses distinct dates, processes or evidence classes that the question requires the learner to separate. Controlling evidence: R. S. Sharma pp. 204-208. [Q32-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. "Mauryas prevented iron and brick technology from leaving Pataliputra." fails this material diffusion hypothesis test. It converts a bounded regional or textual claim into an empire-wide certainty unsupported by the named evidence. Controlling evidence: R. S. Sharma pp. 204-208. [Q32-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. "Every successor copied the Mauryan constitution word for word." fails this material diffusion hypothesis test. It reverses the chronology or causal direction and therefore fails the source-and-sequence test. Controlling evidence: R. S. Sharma pp. 204-208. [Q32-C]
- **D:** Correct. Sharma links iron/steel, bricks, ring wells, routes and state-forming knowledge with the rise of regional powers. The argument is enabling, not technologically deterministic. Named evidence: R. S. Sharma pp. 204-208. Qualification: Legacy can become a condition of decentralisation. [Q32-D]

Examiner trap 32: Legacy can become a condition of decentralisation.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PYQ 01 - 2019 Prelims GS-I Q8: Ranyo Ashoka portrait inscription

Question: In which of the following relief sculpture inscriptions is 'Ranyo Ashoka' (King Ashoka) mentioned along with the stone portrait of Ashoka?

- (A) Kanganahalli
- (B) Sanchi
- (C) Shahbazgarhi
- (D) Sohgaure

Answer/status: A - Kanganahalli

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official paper controls wording; the official key is not held locally.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Option / dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Kanganahalli	Raya/Ranyo Asoko label with royal relief	Correct site and memory evidence	Relief is centuries later, not a lifetime portrait
Sanchi	Ashoka scenes in later relief interpretation	Important Buddhist memory	Not the labelled relief asked
Shahbazgarhi	Kharoshthi Major Rock Edicts	Ashokan public epigraphy	No portrait relief
Sohgaure	Debated early-historic plaque	Administrative/economic history	No Ashoka portrait inscription

Solved analysis

- The answer is Kanganahalli, where a labelled royal relief identifies Ashoka.
- Its significance for Topic 15 is memory: the relief was made long after Ashoka and shows how Buddhist communities visualised a remembered emperor.
- The other options belong to distinct evidence classes - stupa art, rock edicts and an administrative plaque.

Why this earns marks: It identifies the artefact, distinguishes historical memory from eyewitness portraiture, and eliminates distractors by source class.

PYQ discipline: The local official paper controls wording. An unavailable local key is never presented as official.

Demand decoding: Treat "In which of the following relief sculpture inscriptions is 'Ranyo Ashoka' (King Ashoka)..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "In which of the following relief sculpture inscriptions is 'Ranyo Ashoka' (King Ashoka)...", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

PYQ 02 - 2020 Prelims GS-I Q30: Sectarian concord inscription

Question: Who among the following rulers advised his subjects through this inscription: 'Whosoever praises his religious sect or blames other sects out of excessive devotion to his own sect, with the view of glorifying his own sect, he rather injures his own sect very severely'?

- (A) Ashoka
- (B) Samudragupta
- (C) Harshavardhana
- (D) Krishnadeva Raya

Answer/status: A - Ashoka

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The wording is from the local official paper; no local official key is held.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Option / dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Source	Major Rock Edict XII	Restraint in self-praise and condemnation	Translations vary
Positive ideal	Listening and growth in essentials of all sects	Concord beyond passive tolerance	Royal ideal is not proof of harmony
Policy	Respect for Brahmanas and shramanas	Counters anti-Brahmana/purely sectarian reading	Paternal authority remains
Legacy	Public political ethics through inscription	Foundational significance	Reception remains uncertain

Solved analysis

- The quotation condenses Major Rock Edict XII and therefore identifies Ashoka.
- Its significance lies in converting sectarian restraint and mutual listening into a public political ethic.
- It also directly weakens claims that Ashoka pursued a blanket anti-Brahmana policy.

Why this earns marks: It anchors the key to a named edict, explains its political-ethical significance and uses it as counter-evidence in a decline debate.

PYQ discipline: The local official paper controls wording. An unavailable local key is never presented as official.

Demand decoding: Treat "Who among the following rulers advised his subjects through this inscription: 'Whosoever...'" as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Who among the following rulers advised his subjects through this inscription: 'Whosoever...'", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source

class or degree of certainty.

PYQ 03 - 2022 Prelims GS-I Q91: Major Rock Edict site-state pairs

Question: Consider the pairs: Dhauli-Odisha; Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh; Jaugada-Madhya Pradesh; Kalsi-Karnataka. How many are correctly matched?

- (A) Only one pair
- (B) Only two pairs
- (C) Only three pairs
- (D) All four pairs

Answer/status: B - Only two pairs

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official paper is held; the official key is not held.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Option / dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Dhaulti	Odisha	Correct; Kalinga context	Modern administrative names can change
Erragudi/Yerragudi	Andhra Pradesh	Correct; major/minor edict context	Spelling varies
Jaugada	Odisha, not Madhya Pradesh	Kalinga pair with Dhaulti	Do not infer from unfamiliarity
Kalsi	Uttarakhand, not Karnataka	Himalayan-foothill route	Phonetic similarity is a trap

Solved analysis

- Only Dhaulti-Odisha and Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh are correct.
- The question tests the geography of inscriptional communication, a central Mauryan significance.
- Dhaulti and Jaugada should be paired mentally as Kalinga sites; Kalsi belongs to Uttarakhand.

Why this earns marks: It supplies exact corrections and converts map recall into an interpretation of routes, regions and inscriptional governance.

PYQ discipline: The local official paper controls wording. An unavailable local key is never presented as official.

Demand decoding: Treat "Consider the pairs: Dhaulti-Odisha; Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh; Jaugada-Madhya Pradesh; Kalsi-..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Consider the pairs: Dhaulti-Odisha; Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh; Jaugada-Madhya Pradesh; Kalsi-...", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

PYQ 04 - 2025 Prelims GS-I Q19: Pradeshika, Rajuka and Yukta

Question: Ashokan inscriptions suggest that the 'Pradeshika', 'Rajuka' and 'Yukta' were important officers at which level?

- (A) Village-level administration
- (B) District-level administration
- (C) Provincial administration
- (D) Central administration

Answer/status: B - District-level administration

Verification: OFFICIALLY VERIFIED. The local UPSC 2025 Series-A key marks Q19 as B.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Option / dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Pradeshika	Rock Edict III tour context	District-level field role	Not a modern district magistrate
Rajuka	Land/justice/welfare responsibilities	Delegated field authority	Function changed by context
Yukta	Executive/accounting-administrative role	Operational official	Exact hierarchy debated
Collective	Five-year tours	District administration and supervision	Titles were not identical

Solved analysis

- The officially verified answer is district-level administration.
- For significance, the grouping shows a visible field-administrative vocabulary and inspection network.
- For decline, dependence on periodic tours also reveals the costs of supervising distant officials.

Why this earns marks: It uses the official key, names the inscriptional context and extracts both significance and vulnerability without modernising the titles.

PYQ discipline: The local official paper controls wording. An unavailable local key is never presented as official.

Demand decoding: Treat "Ashokan inscriptions suggest that the 'Pradeshika', 'Rajuka' and 'Yukta' were important..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Ashokan inscriptions suggest that the 'Pradeshika', 'Rajuka' and 'Yukta' were important...", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

PYQ 05 - 2023 Prelims GS-I Q42: Stupa origin and function

Question: With reference to ancient India, consider: (1) the concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin; (2) Stupa was generally a repository of relics; (3) Stupa was a votive and commemorative structure in Buddhist tradition. How many statements are correct?

- (A) Only one
- (B) Only two
- (C) All three
- (D) None

Answer/status: B - Only two

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. Primary ownership is Indian Art and Culture; included for Mauryan/post-Mauryan legacy.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Option / dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Statement 1	Funerary mound tradition predates/exceeds Buddhism	Incorrect	Buddhism transformed/popularised the form
Statement 2	Relic enshrinement	Correct for many stupas	Not universal
Statement 3	Votive/commemorative role	Correct	Functions vary by period/site
Mauryan link	Sanchi brick core and Ashokan pillar	Imperial patronage	Visible stone/torana phases are later

Solved analysis

- Statements 2 and 3 are correct; the mound form is not exclusively Buddhist in origin.
- Ashoka's importance lies in patronage, enlargement and inscriptional commemoration, not invention of the stupa.
- Sanchi's Mauryan core and later additions make it a model of continuity through transformation.

Why this earns marks: It answers the objective demand and uses monument layering to explain Mauryan legacy without assigning every visible feature to Ashoka.

PYQ discipline: The local official paper controls wording. An unavailable local key is never presented as official.

Demand decoding: Treat "With reference to ancient India, consider: (1) the concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin;..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "With reference to ancient India, consider: (1) the concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin;...", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

PYQ 06 - 2020 GS-I Q1: Rock-cut architecture and philosophical tradition

Question: Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the monuments and their art in India. Discuss with reference to rock-cut architecture. (10 marks, 150 words)

Answer/status: Model answer

Verification: VERIFIED QUESTION from the local official 2020 GS-I paper. Primary ownership is Indian Art and Culture; included for Mauryan beginnings and legacy.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Option / dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Mauryan beginning	Barabar Ashokan Ajivika dedications	Ascetic use, imperial patronage and rock technology	Not every Barabar cave has the same dedication
Post-Ashoka bridge	Nagarjuni caves dedicated by Dasharatha	Later-Maurya continuity	Does not prove empirewide continuity
Formal translation	Wood/hut forms rendered in stone	Tradition transformed into durable architecture	Specific prototypes are reconstructed
Later plural growth	Bhaja, Karle, Ajanta, Udayagiri-Khandagiri	Buddhist/Jain/Brahmanical expansion	Dates and patrons vary

Solved analysis

- Indian rock-cut architecture translated ascetic, ritual and congregational needs into durable space. The Mauryan starting point is Barabar, where Ashokan inscriptions dedicate polished caves to Ajivikas; this links imperial patronage, renunciant tradition and new stone technology. Dasharatha's Nagarjuni inscriptions continue Ajivika cave patronage after Ashoka, proving selective dynastic and cultural continuity.
- Later Buddhist chaityas and viharas at Bhaja, Karle and Ajanta developed processional, congregational and monastic forms, while Jain and Brahmanical caves widened the religious field. Facades and interiors often translated wooden architectural vocabulary into rock, but chronology and patronage must be established site by site.
- Thus philosophy and tradition shaped function and symbolism, while craft organisation, royal/merchant patronage and material technology shaped the monuments' realised form.

Why this earns marks: It follows the directive, uses Mauryan and post-Mauryan named evidence, broadens to plural traditions and explains how ideas interacted with patronage and technology.

PYQ discipline: The local official paper controls wording. An unavailable local key is never presented as official.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

SIX ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS - EXACT COUNT

ORIGINAL MAINS 10-MARKER 1 - Dynasty, empire and legacy

Question: Distinguish the end of the Maurya dynasty from imperial contraction and the persistence of Mauryan legacy. (10 marks; maximum 150 words)

Demand decoding: Answer the directive directly; organise the body by distinct mechanisms or dimensions; make every paragraph follow claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification; end with a graded verdict.

Model answer (142 words):

Ashoka's death in 232 BCE did not end the Maurya dynasty. Dasharatha's Nagarjuni cave dedications provide the clearest later-Maurya royal inscriptional evidence, while Puranic, Buddhist and Jain lists preserve divergent successor traditions. The conventional c. 187/185 BCE Brihadratha-Pushyamitra episode marks dynastic replacement at Pataliputra, but its army-review detail comes from Bana's much later Harshacharita.

Imperial contraction was a longer regional process: short reigns weakened coordination, north-western pressure narrowed frontier control, and provincial elites gained room to redirect revenue and loyalty. No source supplies a year-by-year map.

Legacy followed a third clock. Prakrit-Brahmi epigraphy, routes, monumental patronage and political vocabulary continued selectively; Sanchi's Mauryan core acquired later Shunga and Satavahana layers. Thus lineage ended, integration fragmented, and repertoires persisted through transformation-not unchanged institutional continuity.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim/evidence units -> counterpoint or limit -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It follows claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Underline the causal verb and source-status qualifier in each paragraph; do not add an unverified date, quotation or official key.

ORIGINAL MAINS 10-MARKER 2 - Inscriptional governance

Question: Explain why Ashoka's inscriptional programme is central to the long-term significance of Mauryan rule. (10 marks; maximum 150 words)

Demand decoding: Answer the directive directly; organise the body by distinct mechanisms or dimensions; make every paragraph follow claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification; end with a graded verdict.

Model answer (150 words):

Ashoka's edicts form the earliest large, securely datable corpus of royal public communication across much of the subcontinent. Rock and pillar inscriptions placed the king's ethical and administrative voice on routes, frontiers and sacred landscapes. Rock Edict XII publicised sectarian restraint; Rock Edict XIII joined remorse with retained deterrence; Rock Edict III named *pradeshikas*, *rajukas* and *yuktas* in a touring framework.

Communication was regionally adapted: Prakrit-Brahmi predominated, Kharoshthi served the north-west, and Greek and Aramaic appeared in selected frontier contexts. This indicates imperial reach without proving identical administration.

The programme's legacy was a durable technology of kingship-public, locatable and reusable by later polities. Yet inscriptions reveal royal intention and mediated proclamation more securely than literacy, comprehension or compliance. Their significance therefore lies in making governance and public ethics visible, not in proving uniform centralisation.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim/evidence units -> counterpoint or limit -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It follows claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Underline the causal verb and source-status qualifier in each paragraph; do not add an unverified date, quotation or official key.

ORIGINAL MAINS 15-MARKER 1 - Significance across dimensions

Question: Assess the political, economic and cultural significance of Mauryan rule while indicating the limits of each claim. (15 marks; maximum 250 words)

Demand decoding: Answer the directive directly; organise the body by distinct mechanisms or dimensions; make every paragraph follow claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification; end with a graded verdict.

Model answer (203 words):

Mauryan rule was significant for combining unprecedented imperial scale with visible governance, connected corridors and monumental communication. Politically, Pataliputra, provincial centres and Ashokan reporting/touring ideals enabled wide coordination. Yet the "first virtually subcontinental empire" was not a modern nation-state: southern neighbours and frontier peoples experienced differentiated relations, and an edict find-spot is not proof of uniform daily control.

Economically, agrarian revenue, roads and rivers, punch-marked coin circulation, crafts, towns, mines, forests and irrigation traditions reveal substantial mobilisation. *Rummindei* records a specific remission, while Pataliputra and route centres show concentration. However, *Arthashastra* monopolies are prescriptive, coin finds do not measure GDP, and urbanisation both preceded and survived Mauryan sovereignty.

Culturally, Prakrit-Brahmi, Kharoshthi, Greek and Aramaic inscriptions adapted royal speech to regions. Dhamma made welfare, restraint and sectarian concord public ethics without abolishing hierarchy or coercion. Pillars, the Sarnath capital, Barabar caves and Sanchi's brick core joined craft, sacred patronage and imperial ideology; later additions must be dated separately.

The durable legacy was therefore a repertoire of scale, communication and material-political forms. Later states selectively reused routes, scripts, titles and monuments, but direct institutional continuity must be demonstrated rather than assumed.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim/evidence units -> counterpoint or limit -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It follows claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Underline the causal verb and source-status qualifier in each paragraph; do not add an unverified date, quotation or official key.

ORIGINAL MAINS 15-MARKER 2 - Chronology and regional weakening

Question: Examine post-Ashoka succession and the regional pattern of Mauryan weakening. (15 marks; maximum 250 words)

Demand decoding: Answer the directive directly; organise the body by distinct mechanisms or dimensions; make every paragraph follow claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification; end with a graded verdict.

Model answer (215 words):

The post-Ashoka phase begins in 232 BCE but is poorly documented. Dasharatha's Nagarjuni cave inscriptions are the only secure later-Maurya royal epigraphy. Kunala, Samprati, Salisuka, Devavarman and Satadhanvan occur in divergent Puranic, Buddhist or Jain traditions; they cannot be arranged with false precision. Brihadratha is conventionally the last Maurya, while the Pushyamitra army-review story is transmitted by the much later Harshacharita. The dynastic boundary is therefore best stated as c. 187/185 BCE.

Contraction was asynchronous. Bactrian Greek pressure affected the north-west and its strategic routes before the dynasty ended at Pataliputra. The Ganga core retained later Mauryas longer, while central India moved into a Shunga-Kanva political sequence. Kalinga and the Deccan followed distinct trajectories; the emergence of Chetis/Mahameghavahanas and Satavahanas should be treated as regional transformation, not a simultaneous 232 BCE revolt.

Sparse post-Ashoka inscriptions indicate reduced imperial visibility, not the exact date of each provincial break. Later Taxila narratives preserve memories of official abuse, whereas the Separate Kalinga Edicts directly reveal Ashoka's anxiety over unjust administration. Together they support possible provincial alienation, not an empire-wide rebellion.

Thus succession instability, communication costs, regional agency and frontier pressure progressively narrowed integration before dynastic replacement completed the transition at the centre.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim/evidence units -> counterpoint or limit -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It follows claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Underline the causal verb and source-status qualifier in each paragraph; do not add an unverified date, quotation or official key.

ORIGINAL MAINS 20-MARKER 1 - Evidence-ranked decline

Question: Critically examine the major explanations for Mauryan decline. Why is a multi-causal model more persuasive? (20 marks; maximum 250 words)

Demand decoding: Answer the directive directly; organise the body by distinct mechanisms or dimensions; make every paragraph follow claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification; end with a graded verdict.

Model answer (240 words):

No single theory explains the chronology, geography and institutional selectivity of Mauryan decline. Weak successors and short reigns could disrupt appointments, command and provincial loyalty, but "weakness" matters only through such mechanisms. Imperial scale imposed communication and fiscal-military burdens; yet differentiated control reduced central costs, and no treasury archive proves bankruptcy.

Provincial alienation is plausible. Taxila's "wicked officials" occur in later Buddhist narrative, while the Separate Kalinga Edicts directly attest concern over arbitrary imprisonment. They establish administrative anxiety, not a coordinated all-India revolt. Bactrian Greek pressure better explains north-western contraction, not fragmentation elsewhere.

Ashoka's pacifism is insufficient: Rock Edict XIII warns forest peoples, Pillar Edict IV presupposes punishment, and no evidence shows army disbandment. H.C. Raychaudhuri's criticism of the peace policy remains a historiographical position, not proof. Haraprasad Sastri's Brahmanical-reaction thesis is weakened by Ashoka's respect for Brahmanas and shramanas and the late, sectarian persecution narratives. R.S. Sharma's fiscal, oppressive-rule, diffusion and frontier hypotheses broaden analysis, but Upinder Singh rejects a proven fiscal or general economic crisis. Debasement, urban decline and ecological collapse need dated regional evidence, absent at empire-wide scale.

The strongest model is interactive: succession shocks weakened compliance and revenue; reduced coordination encouraged provincial assertion; frontier pressure accelerated losses. It explains uneven contraction before the c. 187/185 BCE dynastic end without equating political fragmentation with civilisational collapse.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim/evidence units -> counterpoint or limit -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It follows claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Underline the causal verb and source-status qualifier in each paragraph; do not add an unverified date, quotation or official key.

ORIGINAL MAINS 20-MARKER 2 - Historiography and regional transformation

Question: Evaluate how historiography changes our understanding of Mauryan significance, decline and the transition to the post-Mauryan regional world. (20 marks; maximum 250 words)

Demand decoding: Answer the directive directly; organise the body by distinct mechanisms or dimensions; make every paragraph follow claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification; end with a graded verdict.

Model answer (235 words):

Historiography shifts the question from "which ruler caused collapse?" to "which mechanisms operated where, and what evidence proves them?" H.C. Raychaudhuri's criticism of Ashoka's peace policy represents an older political-military frame. R.S. Sharma foregrounded the costs of army and officialdom, provincial oppression, material diffusion and frontier neglect. D.D. Kosambi's materialist method redirected ancient history toward social and economic formations, but should not become an unsupported single-cause Mauryan thesis.

Romila Thapar expanded analysis beyond dynastic narrative toward ideology, administration and structural conditions, while Upinder Singh warns against anachronistic expectations of ancient states. Singh's evidence-ranked position is crucial: short later reigns and Bactrian Greek pressure matter, but neither state bankruptcy nor an empire-wide economic crisis is proven.

This method also revises significance. Mauryan "unification" meant unprecedented imperial coordination through capitals, routes, officers and inscriptions, not homogeneous national administration. Dhamma was public political ethics with Buddhist roots, not a compulsory creed. Art, scripts and economic networks indicate innovation and interaction mediated regionally.

The post-Mauryan world was neither simple collapse nor direct continuity. Shungas in the Ganga centre, Indo-Greek authority in the north-west and emerging Satavahana power in the Deccan recombined routes, coinage, patronage and political forms differently. Their detailed histories belong to Topic 16 onward; here they show that Mauryan contraction redistributed sovereignty while material and cultural processes continued.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim/evidence units -> counterpoint or limit -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It follows claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Underline the causal verb and source-status qualifier in each paragraph; do not add an unverified date, quotation or official key.